

Lesson 1: Timing and Communication in No Trump Play

1 RACE TO ESTABLISH



establish
your tricks
BEFORE
the opponents

2 CHOOSE THE SOURCE OF TRICKS

ONE-ROUND SUIT

1



High card
takes the trick

TWO-ROUND SUIT

1



→

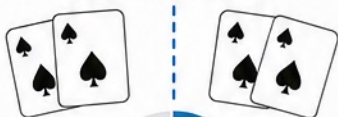


Play high, then
play again

3 IMPORTANT PERCENTAGES

3-3 SPLIT = 36%

(less than 1 in 3)



Less than
1 in 3

3-2 SPLIT = 68%

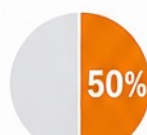
(2 in 3)



2 in 3

FINESSE = 50%

(1 in 2)



1 in 2

4 DANGEROUS OPPONENT



the defender
who must
NOT gain
the lead



5 DUCKING THE OPENING LEAD

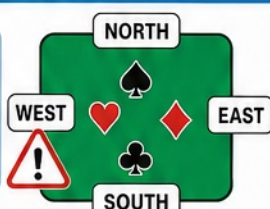


cut the
defenders'
communication



6 EXAMPLE

If West has
the long suit,
do NOT let
West gain
the lead!



7 DECISION TREE: "WHO IS DANGEROUS? HOW DO I AVOID THEM?"

WHO IS DANGEROUS?

The defender
who can cash
their tricks
and lead again.



CAN THEY GAIN THE LEAD?

YES

HOW CAN I AVOID THEM?

GOOD!
Keep control.
Establish your tricks.



Duck the opening lead.



Play early in a suit.



Establish your tricks fast.



Do NOT let the dangerous opponent gain the lead!

LESSON 2: OPENING EVALUATIONS

1 THE 5 FLAWS OF 11-POINT HANDS



FEW HIGH CARDS
(NOT CONCENTRATED)



HONOR IMPURITIES
(ISOLATED HONORS)



NON-COMPETITIVE SUITS
(TOO SHORT)



UNFAVORABLE POSITION
(HONORS BEHIND
THE OPENER)



POOR SECOND BID

**2 RULE: WITH 2 OR MORE
FLAWS ON 11 POINTS
→ PASS!**

5 11 POINTS: OPEN OR PASS?

CHECK YOUR FLAWS:



FEW HIGH CARDS

☐


HONOR IMPURITIES

☐


NON-COMPETITIVE SUITS

☐


UNFAVORABLE POSITION

☐


POOR SECOND BID

☐

TOTAL FLAWS:

0-1 FLAW

OPEN! 😊

2 OR MORE FLAWS

PASS! 😞



RULE:

WITH 2 OR MORE
FLAWS ON 11 POINTS



PASS!

3 PREEMPTIVE BIDS

**3
LEVEL**

OPENING AT LEVEL 3:
7+ HONORED CARDS



"3 TRICKS LESS"

**4
LEVEL**

OPENING AT LEVEL 4:
8+ CARDS



EVEN MORE AGGRESSIVE
MESSAGE

4 EVALUATE DISTRIBUTION

4432

MUCH BETTER
THAN 4333



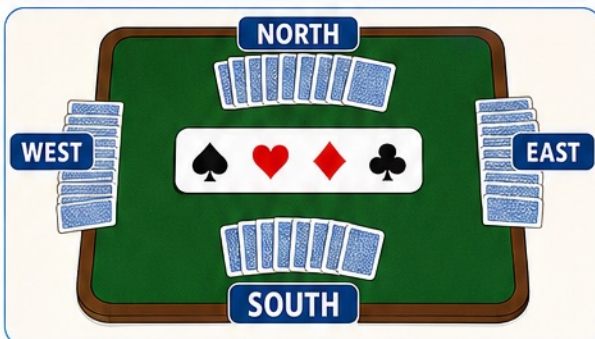
♠ 4
♥ 4
♦ 3
♣ 2

4333

♠ 4
♥ 3
♦ 3
♣ 3



THE MORE DISTRIBUTED
THE HAND, THE MORE IT IS WORTH.





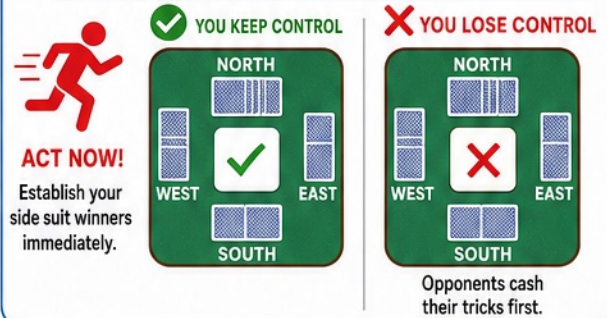
FIGB

Lesson 3: Trump Contracts - Timing and Control

1 DISCARD ON SIDE WINNERS: do it **BEFORE** drawing trumps!



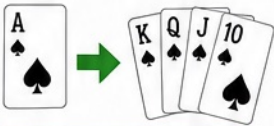
2 **URGENCY** to establish the side suit: if you don't do it immediately, you **lose control**



3 **LEGITIMATE** vs **ILLEGITIMATE TRUMP**

LEGITIMATE TRUMP

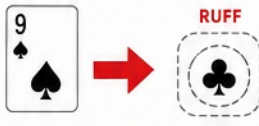
Trump played to draw opponents' trumps.



✓ Purpose: take away the opponents' trumps.

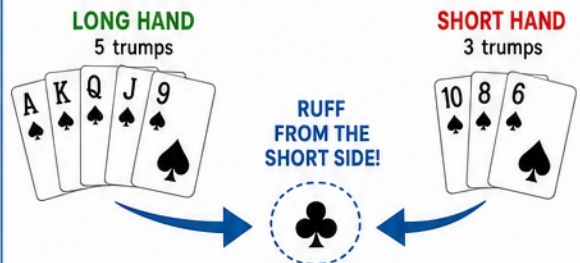
ILLEGITIMATE TRUMP

Trump used for a ruff (extra trick).



✗ Purpose: not to draw trumps, but to ruff.

4 **RUFF FROM THE SHORT SIDE:** only this way you gain extra tricks



★ Ruff from the short side = extra trick!

5 **THE 4-4 FIT:** the most powerful in bridge!



WHY?

Both hands can ruff in the other suit.
This generates more tricks.

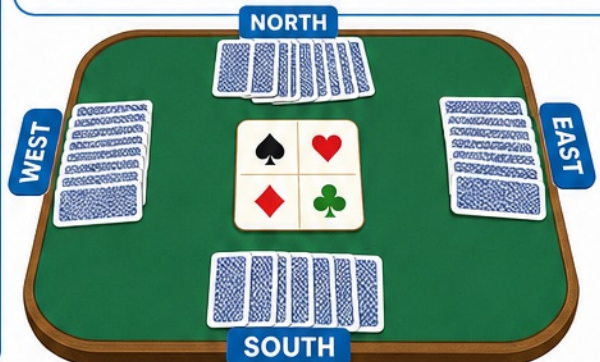
4-4 FIT
BOTH HANDS
CAN RUFF



5-3 FIT
ONLY ONE HAND
CAN RUFF



4-4 FIT GENERATES MORE TRICKS THAN A 5-3 FIT!



6 **SCHEME: FIRST DISCARD, THEN DRAW TRUMPS, THEN CASH**

1 FIRST DISCARD

Discard losers on your side suit winners.



2 THEN DRAW TRUMPS

Draw all the opponents' trumps.



3 THEN CASH

Cash your winners and enjoy your tricks!





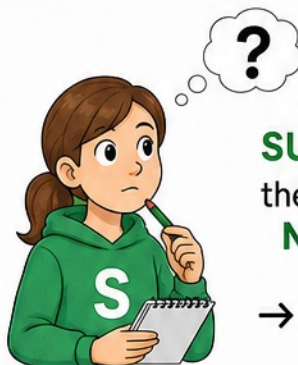
FIGB

Lesson 4: The Captaincy and the Opener's Rebids

1. CAPTAIN vs SUBORDINATE



CAPTAIN:
the one who knows
the partnership's
combined strength
→ **DECIDES**



SUBORDINATE:
the one who does
NOT know yet
→ **DESCRIBES**



If the Captain
INQUIRES
→ the Subordinate
describes



If the Captain
DECIDES
→ the Subordinate
passes!

2. GOLDEN RULE

3. OPENER'S REBID (FIGB STANDARD RANGE)



Suit rebid (beyond the LDG)
= **17–19** points

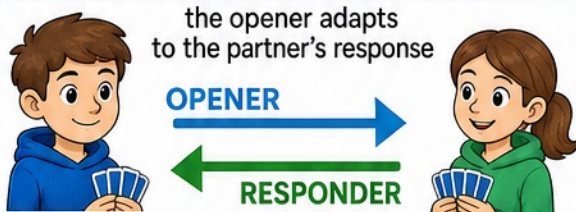


Jump in a new suit
(strong rebid)
= **20–21** points

2NT

Jump to 2NT
= **18–19** balanced points
with a stopper

4. FLEXIBLE RESPONSES



DECISION FLOW

Responder makes a bid



EVALUATE
the meaning

Opener evaluates



CHOOSE
the best rebid

Opener rebids



REBID
with purpose

5. EXAMPLE: "1♠ – 2♣ – ?" → THE OPENER REBIDS BASED ON THEIR STRENGTH



South (Opener) rebids
based on strength
and hand type:

2♥

17–19 points
Suit rebid beyond the LDG

2♦

17–19 points
Suit rebid beyond the LDG

3♠

20–21 points
Jump in a new suit (strong rebid)

2NT

18–19 points
Balanced with a stopper



REMEMBER

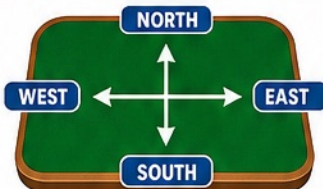
- Know your role: Captain decides, Subordinate describes.
- Follow the **Golden Rule!**
- Rebids show your strength and shape.

LESSON 5: BROKEN SUITS – HOW TO HANDLE HONORS



1 FIRST TO MOVE IS AT A DISADVANTAGE:

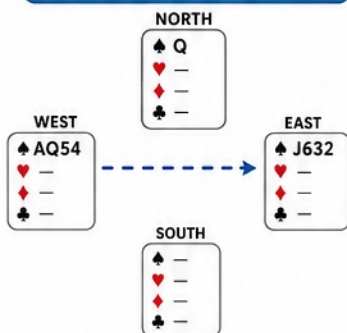
play towards honors,
not from them



When you lead from
an honor, you reduce
your chances.
Lead towards honors
to give your hand
the best chance!

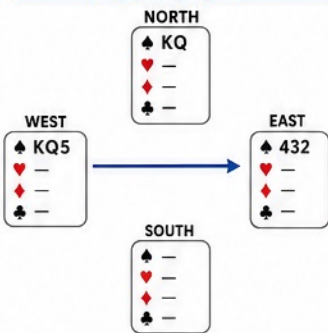
2 SPECIFIC HONORS

1) AQ54 + J632:
finesse towards the Queen



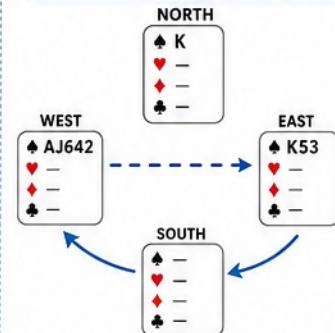
Lead towards the Queen.
If East has the King, the Queen
wins the trick.

2) KQ5 + 432:
play towards KQ



Play towards the King-Queen.
If East has the Ace, your KQ
will score the tricks.

3) AJ642 + K53:
combine finesse and length



Finesse towards the Jack.
Then use your length to
take the remaining tricks.

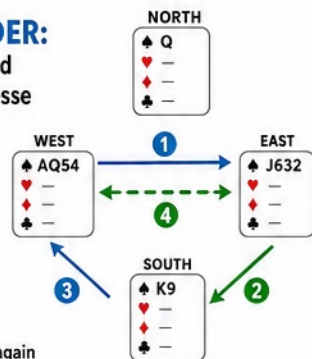
3 ENTRY LADDER:

entries are needed
to repeat the finesse



You need a way
back to your hand
to try the finesse
again!

- 1 Lead towards the Queen
- 2 Return to hand (entry)
- 3 Lead towards the Queen again
- 4 Repeat until suit is established



4 GOLDEN RULE:



Missing 1 honor
+ 2-3 small cards = **FINESSE**



Missing 1 honor
+ only 1 small card = **PLAY HIGH**



6 SUMMARY CHART:

WHEN TO FINESSE VS PLAY HIGH

YOUR HAND	OPPONENT LIKELY HOLDS	PLAN	WHY?
Missing 1 honor + 2-3 small cards	Honor (e.g., K or A)	FINESSE	Good chance honor is with the opponent.
Missing 1 honor + only 1 small card	Honor (e.g., K or A)	PLAY HIGH	High chance honor is behind you.
Missing 2+ honors	Unpredictable	PLAY HIGH	Finessing twice is too risky.
Long suit (5+ cards)	Any	Use length + entries	Create extra tricks after establishing suit.

5 PROBE PLAY:

play to discover
the position of
opponents' honors



A probe lead is a small card
played early to learn where
the missing honors are
before committing your
important cards.



PRACTICE, OBSERVE, AND THINK AHEAD.
GOOD DECLARERS MAKE PLANS AND FOLLOW THROUGH!

Maestro Franci



FIGB

LESSON 6: OPENINGS BEYOND LEVEL 1

1 LEVEL 2 OPENINGS

BID	MEANING	DETAILS
2♦	Forcing to 3 in the opened suit	6+ good cards in the suit, approximately 16–20 points
2♥	Forcing to 3 in the opened suit	6+ good cards in the suit, approximately 16–20 points
2♠	Forcing to 3 in the opened suit	6+ good cards in the suit, approximately 16–20 points

2 2♣ OPENING (THE STRONGEST!)

2♣

AMBIGUOUS CONTAINER

Can be:

- Balanced hand with 23+ points
- OR
- Very strong Clubs base (often 8+ clubs and strong overall)



2♦

WAITING RESPONSE

"I have nothing special, you describe."

3 ROMAN KEY CARD BLACKWOOD (4NT)



4NT

Asks for the
5 KEY CARDS:
4 Aces +
trump King

RESPONSE	MEANING
5♣	0 or 3 key cards
5♦	1 or 4 key cards
5♥	2 or 5 key cards WITHOUT the Queen of trumps
5♠	2 or 5 key cards WITH the Queen of trumps

4 GAMBLING 3NT BARRAGE



3NT

Use when you have:

- A solid minor suit (**AKQxxxx**)
- No side tricks



You are betting that your minor suit will provide all the tricks!

5 LEVELS OF OPENING: FROM WEAKEST TO STRONGEST

WEAKEST

1♣

3+ clubs
0–7 points

<

1♦

3+ diamonds
0–7 points

<

1♥

5+ hearts
0–12 points

<

1♠

5+ spades
0–12 points

<

1NT

15–17 points
Balanced

2♦/2♥/2♠

6+ in the suit
16–20 points
Forcing to 3

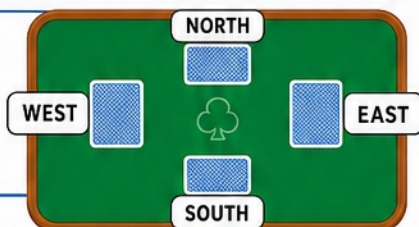
STRONGEST

2♣

Strongest!
23+ balanced or
very strong clubs

THE BRIDGE TABLE

Bridge is played by
4 players around
the table.



REMEMBER

Good openings help you
and your partner find
the best contract!

Maestro Franci

LESSON 7:

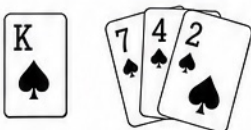
OPENING LEADS AND DEFENSIVE SIGNALS

1 ATTITUDE

→ **SMALL** card =
I have an honor
in the suit

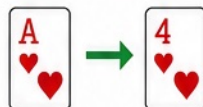


→ **HIGH** card =
I do NOT have
honors in the suit



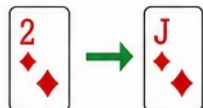
2 COUNT (order of cards)

EVEN (high then low) =
even number of
cards in the suit



Example:
A then 4
(2 cards)

ODD (low then high) =
odd number of
cards



Example:
2 then J
(3 cards)

3 ODD-EVEN ATTITUDE



Even card =
like
(continue!)



Odd card =
dislike
(change suit!)



4 ITALIAN FIRST DISCARD



ODD card =
calls for that suit
(you want it!)



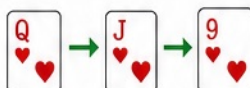
EVEN card =
denies that suit
(you don't want it!)



5 SIGNAL HIERARCHY



SEQUENCES
always take precedence
over count



This is a
SEQUENCE.
It is more important
than count.



Do not use count
when you can show
a sequence.

6 WHICH SIGNAL DO I USE? WHEN?

Is a sequence
available?



YES

Use a **SEQUENCE**.
It always takes
precedence.

NO

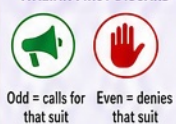
Do you have an opinion
about partner's call
or the suit led?

YES

ODD-EVEN ATTITUDE



ITALIAN FIRST DISCARD



COUNT (ORDER)

EVEN (high then low)
= even number
ODD (low then high)
= odd number

ATTITUDE



NO

Use **ATTITUDE**.

Small = I have honor
High = I do NOT
have honors





LESSON 8: APPROACHING GAME

1 THIRD SUIT

- Forcing for one round or game forcing
- Used when there is no fit and the right denomination is being sought

EXAMPLE

WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
—	1 ♥	—	1 ♠
—	2 ♦	—	2 ♣
—	2 ♥	—	2 ♠
—	3 ♦	—	?

North bids a third suit to ask about values and the right strain.

2 FOURTH SUIT

- Game FORCING (except at level 1)
- Conventional: does not promise cards in the suit



3 OPENER'S BEHAVIOR ON FOURTH SUIT (PRIORITY)

- 1st** Show major fit (3 cards)
- 2nd** Bid No Trump with a stopper
- 3rd** Show additional lengths

4 SUIT CHANGE WITH FIT FOUND

- Investigations for game or slam
- It is not a rejection of the fit!



5 2NT AS A GENERAL INVITATION

Shows about **11** points, balanced.

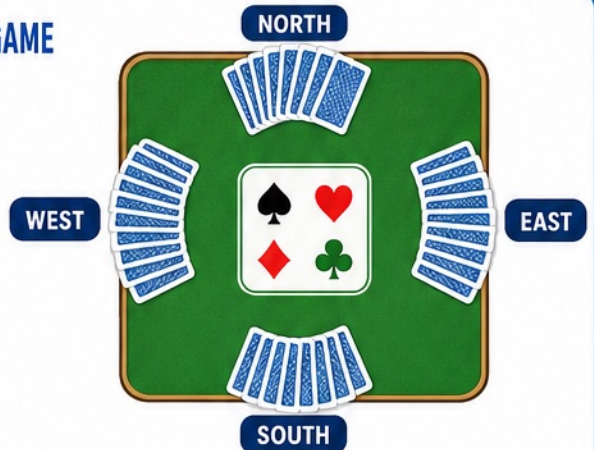


6 EXAMPLE: BIDDING PATH FROM OPENING TO GAME

WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
—	1 ♠	—	1 ♥
—	2 ♣*	—	2 ♥
—	2NT	—	3 ♠
—	4 ♠	—	5 ♣*
—	5 ♦	—	6 ♠
—	—	—	—

- Opening and response
- Third suit (game forcing)
- Invitational and showing fit
- Fourth suit (game forcing)
- Control exploration and slam try
- Game reached!

* Fourth suit – game forcing (does not promise cards in the suit)





FIGB

Lesson 9: Receiving the Opening Lead

1 DEDUCTIONS FROM THE OPENING LEAD

OPENING LEAD	WHAT IT TYPICALLY MEANS
LOW 5 4 2	→ HAS AN HONOR
HIGH K 10 7	→ NO HONOR
HONOR Q J 9	→ SEQUENCE

2 FUNDAMENTAL RULE



NO ONE LEADS UNDER AN ACE IN TRUMP!



If they lead low, they do **NOT** have the Ace.

3 DUCKING SPECIFIC HONORS



LEAD:
K

DUCK!
(let the King win)

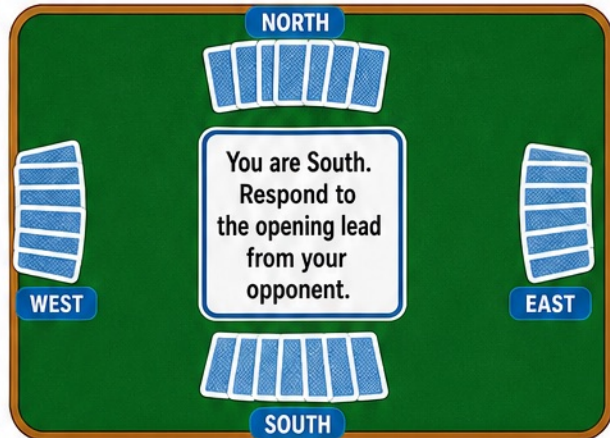


LEAD:
K

DUCK!
(let the King win)



Duck when it helps your long-term plan.



4 DUCKING FOR PLAY PLAN



Sometimes you duck to **maintain control** of the suit.



Duck to **break** defensive communications.

5 PROTECTING THE ACE FROM A RUFF



If you risk a ruff, **take immediately** with the Ace.

I'll ruff!

6 TAKE OR DUCK? DECISION TREE



Is the card dangerous if you duck?

YES

TAKE IT!
Don't let them gain advantage.

NO

CAN YOU BENEFIT BY DUCKING?

YES

DUCK!
It supports your plan.

NO

CONSIDER THE CONTEXT
Score, vulnerability, declarer's plan, etc.



GOOD DECISIONS
BRING THE CONTRACT DOWN!



THINK, PLAN, AND PLAY SMART!
Every lead gives you information.
Use it to your advantage!

Maestro Franci

LESSON 10: THE DOUBLE AND THE REBID



1 DOUBLE vs REBID

D DOUBLE



seeks the
best suit fit

R REBID



promises
already found fit
+ strength

2 OPENER'S PARTNER



- Double = seeks fit with the responder
- Rebid = found fit + strength for game

3 OVERCALLER'S PARTNER



- Rebid with 11+ points and fit
- With 14+ points even without fit

4 DOUBLER'S PARTNER

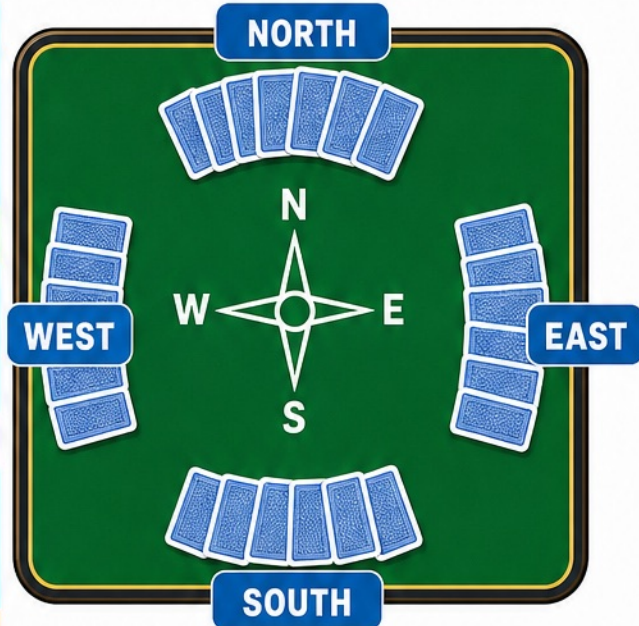


- Mandatory Rebid with 11+ points
- Below 11 points: bid at the minimum level

5 OPENER'S DOUBLE AND REBID



- The opener can double or rebid after the overcall



6 WHO DOES WHAT AND WHEN

 PARTNER OF...	D DOUBLE	R REBID	 WHEN	 GOAL
 OPENER	Seeks fit with the responder	Found fit + strength for game	After partner's response	 Find best fit and reach the best contract
 OVERCALLER	Usually does not double	11+ points and fit (14+ even without fit)	After the overcall	 Show strength and compete in the auction
 DOUBLER	Already took action (doubled)	Mandatory with 11+ points	Next bid	 Clarify strength and describe your hand
 OPENER	Can double after overcall	Can rebid after overcall	After the overcall	 Support partner and compete for the contract

LESSON 11: DEFENSE – REASONING AND DEDUCTION



1



REMEMBER THE BIDDING:

- Reconstruct the declarer's hand from the auction
- Points shown + promised distribution

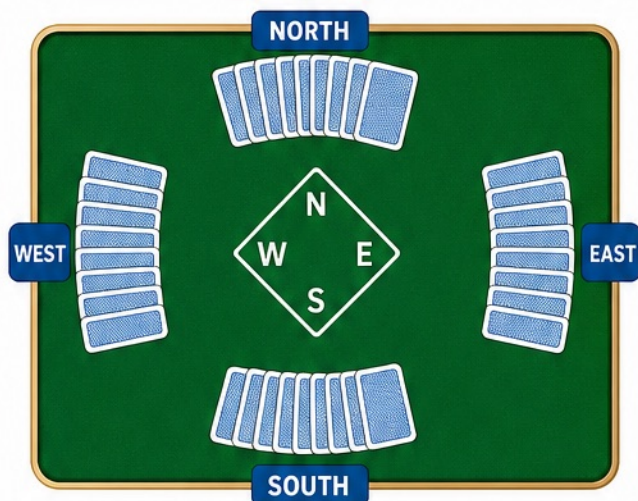
EXAMPLE AUCTION			
WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
Pass	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♥
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
Pass	Pass	Pass	(All Pass)

2



ANALYZE THE FIRST TRICK:

- Which card did partner play? (signal)
- Which card did the declarer play? (deduction)



3



DO NOT ESTABLISH CARDS FOR THE DECLARER:

- Do not play Aces on small cards
- Wait for the right moment to take

4



UNDERSTAND THE PLAY PLAN AND COUNTER IT:

- If the declarer wants to ruff → play trumps!
- If the declarer wants to establish → cut the links!

5



MAINTAIN THE SAME LENGTH AS THE DUMMY:

- If the dummy has 4 Hearts, keep 4 Hearts
- "Keep what the dummy keeps"

THE 5 STEPS OF THE THINKING DEFENDER

1



REMEMBER THE BIDDING

Reconstruct the declarer's hand from the auction.

2



ANALYZE THE FIRST TRICK

Look at partner's card (signal) and the declarer's card (deduction).

3



DO NOT ESTABLISH CARDS FOR THE DECLARER

Do not play Aces on small cards. Wait for the right moment to take.

4



UNDERSTAND THE PLAY PLAN AND COUNTER IT

If the declarer wants to ruff → play trumps!
If the declarer wants to establish → cut the links!

5



MAINTAIN THE SAME LENGTH AS THE DUMMY

If the dummy has 4 Hearts, keep 4 Hearts.
"Keep what the dummy keeps."



THINK, OBSERVE, DEDUCE!

Good defenders don't guess. They think, observe and take the right actions!

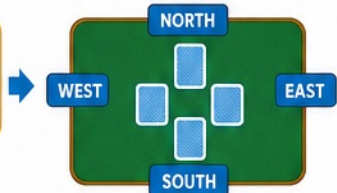
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Lesson 12: Overcalls and Reopening Bids

1 TAKEOUT DOUBLE + REBID

 With **18+** points:
Double then
rebid (removal)

 Shows a hand
too strong for
a simple overcall.



WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
1 ♣	Pass	1 ♦	Pass
Double	Pass	2 ♥	Pass

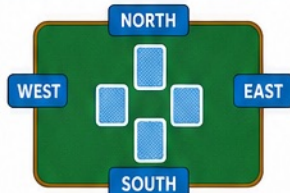
Double shows values and support. Rebid shows Hearts and removes (denies) the minor.

2 JUMP OVERCALL AT THE 2 LEVEL

 6 good cards
(at least 2 honors)

 11-15 points

 Example:
1 ♣ - 2 ♥ =
6 good Hearts,
medium strength.



WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
1 ♣	Pass	2 ♥	Pass



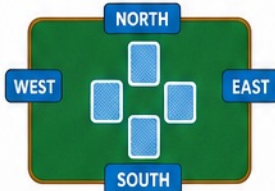
A jump overcall shows a strong, preemptive hand with that suit.

3 2NT MINOR TWO-SUITER 5-5

 Shows at least
5 ♦ and 5 ♣.

 Variable strength,
depends on
vulnerability.

 Good shape in the
two minor suits.



WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
1 ♥	Pass	2NT	Pass



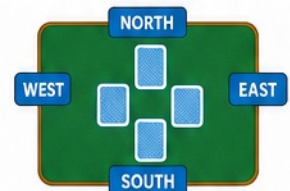
You must have at least 5 Diamonds and 5 Clubs.

4 STRONG PASS + PARTNER'S REOPENING

 Pass with a
strong hand =
trap!

 You passed,
so stay quiet...

 Partner **MUST**
reopen with
a Double.



WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
1 ♦	Pass	Pass	Pass
Double	Pass	Pass	Pass



Your Double says: "I have a strong hand. Let's compete!"

5 REOPENING WITH A SUIT vs DOUBLE

REOPEN WITH A SUIT

 You have
5+ cards
in that suit.

 Few points,
mainly length.

Example: With 5+ Hearts
and 4-9 points, reopen 1 ♥.

REOPEN WITH A DOUBLE

 You have a
suitable
distribution.

 10+ points,
strong hand.

Example: With 10+ points
and a good shape, reopen
with a Double.

VS

6 TYPES OF OVERCALLS AND WHEN TO USE THEM

TYPE	WHAT IT SHOWS	POINT RANGE	WHEN TO USE
 Takeout Double + Rebid	Values and support. Rebid shows your suit and removes.	18+ points	Hand too strong for a simple overcall.
 Jump Overcall at the 2 Level	6 good cards in the suit (at least 2 honors).	11-15 points	Preemptive, medium strength.
 2NT Minor Two-Suiter 5-5	At least 5 ♦ and 5 ♣.	Variable, depends on vulnerability	When you have both minor suits well established.
 Strong Pass + Reopening (Double)	Strong hand. Partner must reopen with a Double.	Usually 10+ points	After passing, let partner compete.
 Reopen with a Suit vs Double	Suit = 5+ cards, few points. Double = good shape, 10+ points.	Suit: 4-9 points Double: 10+ points	Choose the bid that describes your hand best.

QUICK TIPS

- ✓ Know your strength and distribution.
- ✓ Communicate clearly with your partner.
- ✓ Use the right tool at the right time.
- ✓ Great partnerships win more tricks!



Maestro Franci